

Changing the Face of College Fashion

*Request for Funding for an Event Series Promoting Sustainable Fashion Practices at the
University of Massachusetts Amherst*



Written on behalf of Fashion Revolution USA

Authored by Amy Flynn

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Dear Board of Trustee Members,

Please consider this letter as part of the formal request for funding in the amount of \$10,000 for a proposed project between Fashion Revolution USA and the University of Massachusetts Amherst. Fashion Revolution USA is dedicated to educating communities about the surprisingly severe impacts of the fashion industry on climate change and is particularly versed in working with higher education institutions. It is a topic that is highly neglected in current climate change conversations, which we are working on changing. The project, tentatively titled *Changing the Face of College Fashion*, will involve an on-campus event series focused on the initiation and education of sustainable fashion practices among the student body and the surrounding community.

The event series involves a monthly large-scale swap/tag sale open to students and the public on the University's campus. The plan for the events involves opportunities for students to sell and barter used clothing or things at individual booths, local non-profit thrift stores to promote themselves to the student body and surrounding community, and Fashion Revolution USA to educate a larger audience about their mission of sustainable fashion practices. It will also allow the University to further its commitment to sustainability on campus and promote campus engagement among the student body post-pandemic. The main costs covered by funding will involve the employment of an event planner plus the price of required event and marketing materials.

The aim of this event series is to promote sustainability on campus and in the surrounding community through repurposing and recycling secondhand goods, which is a common goal of both the University and Fashion Revolution USA. Fashion Revolution USA specifically focuses on partnerships with higher education institutions, so it will be a smooth process of coordination between the organizations. It will be very beneficial for both parties to promote sustainability initiatives and community engagement in tandem.

Thank you for your time and consideration,

Amy Flynn

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I. Statement of Need

A. *Unsustainable Fashion's Massive Environmental Impact*

Many people are unaware of the fashion industry's shockingly significant part in the climate crisis. 10% of carbon emissions are produced exclusively by the fashion industry, but according to the Geneva Environment Network's latest report that number could reach over 25% in the next three decades. This is because production has focused on minimizing costs for companies in the last few years. Firms have moved labor production overseas into areas that have potentially more relaxed regulations of working conditions, contributing to serious ethical questions. Beyond that, quality materials have been foregone towards the end of cranking out lesser-quality products for rapidly produced fashion lines: as just one example of this, fast-fashion giant Shein puts out between 700 and 1000 new styles a day¹. Between cutting costs for fiber and garment production, transportation, and disposal, the environmental impact of the fashion industry is quickly catching up to us. Expanding our carbon footprint is just the tip of the iceberg, though. The fashion industry also consumes the second-most amount of water as any other industry; in fact, a 2020 report from the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development put the figure at 93 billion cubic meters--which is half the annual amount that Americans drink. However, the fashion industry does not just use huge amounts of water. It also pollutes it, and statistically is responsible for around 20% of international industrial wastewater

¹ <https://insideclimatenews.org/todaysclimate/gen-z-has-a-fast-fashion-problem-thats-bad-for-the-climate-and-equity/>

pollution. That is not all, though; microplastics in the fibers that are produced in the fashion industry also make up a significant portion of the plastics that pollute ocean water.²

The graphic below, from a study in *Nature Reviews Earth & Environment*, shows the past and present environmental price of fast fashion. Since 1970, fiber production for clothes has been hugely responsible for world pollution, and there is no end in sight as unsustainable production continues.³

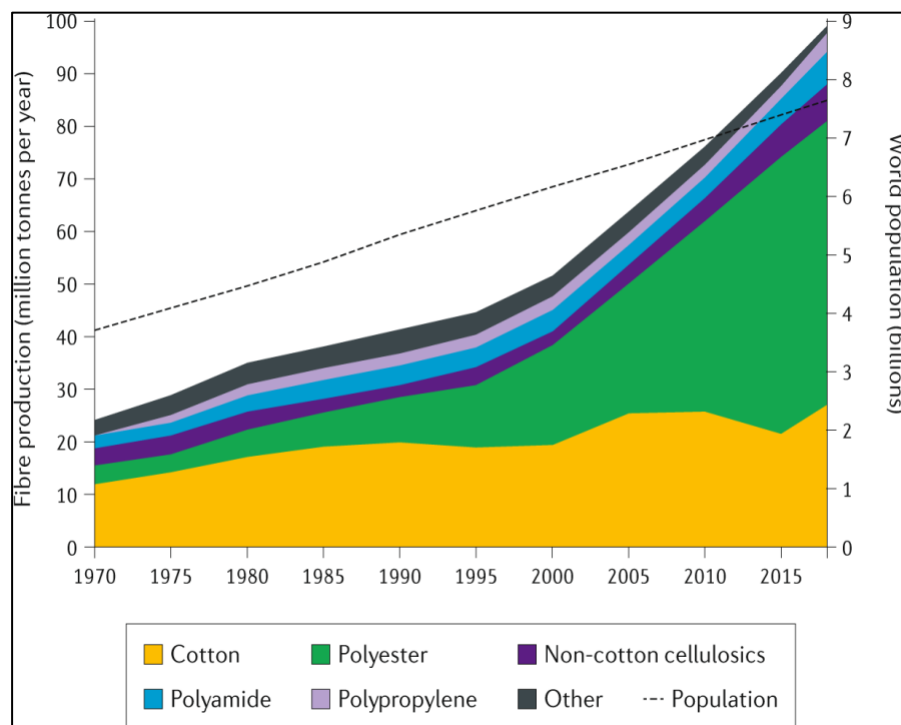


Figure 1: In the last fifty years, world pollution has increased at an alarming rate because of fashion production. This is only predicted to increase.

² <https://www.wri.org/insights/apparel-industrys-environmental-impact-6-graphics>

³ <https://www.nature.com/articles/s43017-020-0039-9>

The consumption of fashion is not just problematic because of the means of production that hurts our environment so significantly. Disposal is also a huge issue, and our current rate of consumption contributes to massive amounts of general waste. In fact, every second the equivalent of one garbage truck of clothes is disposed of in a landfill.⁴ All of this adds up, yet society is still largely unaware of how much their shopping habits contribute to the rapidly increasing degradation of our environment.

B. Fast Fashion & Consumerism Among College-Age Students

These critical influences on our environment are especially problematic because fashion has been overly commodified in the last few decades, particularly for college-aged students. Consumers are buying 60% more clothing than previously and wearing them for half the time they used to in the United States. Some say our increased consumption of clothing is because of new online shopping capabilities, while others some say it is because of current cultural focus on appearance and material success. Whatever it is, the world buys over 80 billion new pieces of clothing annually. To put that in perspective, this is 400% more than fashion consumption only twenty years ago per Fashion United's global statistics. Yet, our consumption is not even remotely matching our use; we are overwhelmingly buying more and more clothes that are not needed. The graphic below shows how international clothing production doubled between 2000 and 2015, whereas the use of clothing has steadily declined in those years: this is exactly what defines this era of fast fashion-induced climate destruction we are currently living in.

⁴ <https://www.unep.org/news-and-stories/story/putting-brakes-fast-fashion>

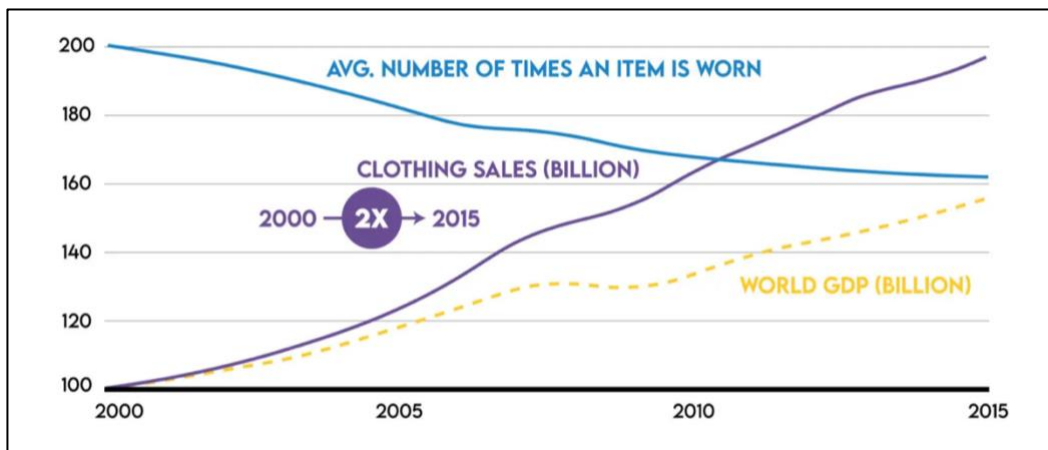


Figure 2: Growth of Clothing Sales and Decline in Clothing Utilization Since 2000 (via Ellen MacArthur Foundation & Earth.Org)

C. *The Real Solution to Fast Fashion*

Currently, the model of fashion production involves the consumption of too many resources followed by a short life cycle and then disposal in a landfill. It is not a sustainable model, as all the facts have so clearly shown up to this point. There are ways to make this a more circular model of production, which is touted by experts such as the MacArthur Foundation as a method of design that would stop designing products with waste as the end point, re-use products and materials, and leave more room for natural resources to regenerate as opposed to deplete continually. However, this would require huge regulatory changes from governments and companies. Luckily, there are impactful things individuals can do beyond redesigning the broader economy. Sustainable fashion experts have said that educating the public and buying secondhand/repurposing clothes is the best way individuals can help combat the fashion-induced crisis on a more realistic scale.⁵ This is exactly how we've structured our plan for our on-campus

⁵ <https://news.climate.columbia.edu/2021/06/10/why-fashion-needs-to-be-more-sustainable/>

event series: educate the campus and community about the broader unsustainable fashion practices that must be implemented while actually implementing the second-best solutions—thrifting and repurposing existing wasteful materials.

D. Relevance to Specifically the UMass Community

Given the severity of the climate crisis, college campuses are being pushed towards making choices for greater sustainability. In just the last few years, UMass has installed the largest campus solar panel network in New England and committed to changing to 100% renewable energy, among many other things. The campus is obviously committed to working on the climate crisis, but there have been no concrete actions towards the issues of unsustainable fashion despite the considerable role it plays in the climate crisis. There have been small-scale, disorganized efforts by students around campus towards this end; the Civic Engagement and Service-Learning program has a weekly item swap, the Sustainable Business and Fashion club works towards promoting sustainability on campus, and many people attend the farmer's markets on Goodell lawn where there are sometimes tables with secondhand items. Though admirable that members of the campus community have recognized the lack of engagement in this area, it speaks to how much of a need there is for this to happen on a larger scale.

UMass Amherst is also a perfect community for a project series of this kind because of the demographic it serves. Approximately three-quarters of the student population is between the ages of 18-24, which is an age group that falls among Generation Z.⁶ Studies have proven that Gen-Z own more clothes than other generations and on average own “hundreds of dollars worth

⁶ <https://www.collegefactual.com/colleges/university-of-massachusetts-amherst/student-life/diversity/>

of outfits that never get worn at all.”⁷ UMass Amherst has an opportunity to target education of sustainable fashion at the demographic who needs it most and is most accessible on campus. Fashion Revolution USA can help the University make this commitment with an organized effort towards this end.

This project will also be beneficial for the University of Massachusetts Amherst to promote campus engagement. The University is dealing with a student population that almost half of which has a limited experience with on-campus life. There has been a push to reintegrate people into campus life and return the University of Massachusetts Amherst to its pre-pandemic prime. Hosting events like this that are easy and free for students to attend while making strides toward sustainability is valuable.

II. Statement of Request

The request for funding is on behalf of Fashion Revolution USA from the University of Massachusetts Amherst. Fashion Revolution USA is a chapter of the internationally based organization Fashion Revolution, and it specifically places significant focus on events and education “to help create an inclusive U.S. fashion system that conducts business ethically, regenerates the environment, and produces responsibly, supporting all voices across the apparel network.”⁸ The Education team of Fashion Revolution USA is well-versed in dealing with higher

⁷ <https://insideclimatenews.org/todaysclimate/gen-z-has-a-fast-fashion-problem-thats-bad-for-the-climate-and-equity/>

⁸ <https://www.fashionrevolution.org/north-america/usa/>

education and has previously worked on partnerships with universities, which should appeal to the University of Massachusetts Amherst as a serious candidate for funding.

For this event series to fulfill our goal of committing to sustainable fashion practices and educating the campus community, we are asking the University of Massachusetts to allocate \$10,000 in funding towards the implementation of the event series. This will be used to coordinate the event itself with an event planner, supplies, and marketing materials as well as develop the educational material of the event. Given the nature of Fashion Revolution USA's non-profit status, the events will be free and opened to the surrounding community to promote engagement and broader education. The events will take place monthly on the University of Massachusetts' campus. We'd also like to include local thrift stores and the public if they'd like to come with some of their second-hand goods. This will be a totally open event because the goal is clear: to provide a space to educate and implement the repurposing of second-hand goods towards the end of greater sustainability in the Amherst community. As this is a common goal of both the University and Fashion Revolution USA, we believe this partnership will be meaningful and impactful.



Figure 3: Fashion Revolution USA has made leaps and bounds towards sustainability in the world, a common goal of both UMass Amherst and the organization.

III. Description of Proposed Work

A. Objectives

- Educate the community about the severity of unsustainable fashion on the environment
- Provide a space to repurpose second-hand goods as per experts' recommendation of tackling the fashion climate crisis on a realistic scale
- Engage the campus and surrounding community with a totally free, public event series in the post-pandemic era
- Further the University's commitment to sustainability on campus
- Organize the small-scale existing efforts on campus into an organized, impactful event

B. Logistics

We propose eight monthly events during the academic year starting in September 2023 and going through May 2024, excluding December 2023 because of winter break. The grant proposal only cover funds for that first year, and we will ensure that our progress is tracked diligently to hopefully prove success and acquire funding for following years.

The event series will be located on the UMass campus as a focal point of the community. Ideally, the event could be held outside on Goodell Lawn when weather permitted, but to avoid paying for space it could otherwise be held in the free space of the Campus Center basement. This is up to campus administration.

Attendance will be completely open, but we'd like to target the community, local thrift stores, and most importantly the student body. We are thinking of this as an open-concept table-oriented event. People could register in advance to have their own table if they had many items to bring, or they could bring things last-minute to a section open for individual swapping and

selling. The actual terms of selling and swapping will be completely up to individual interactions and there will be no set guidelines or prices unless the individual decided to set those for their items themselves. We picture local thrift stores having their own registered tables and having a few tables dispersed among the area run by Fashion Revolution USA and/or UMass volunteers that will have educational material and information for attendees to push the sustainable fashion



Figure 4: We picture a walkable, table event in a similar fashion to the Amherst Farmer's Market but with exclusively second-hand/thrifted items.

initiative.

C. *Timeline*

Assuming we move forward with this project in the start of 2023, there will be roughly nine months (January-September) to set up the groundwork for the event series. This is our estimate of timing for those nine months up until the first event, with plenty of flexible time:

TIMELINE OF INITIAL SETUP FOR EVENT SERIES			
Phase of Project	Start Date	End Date	Time of Proposed Phase
<i>Vet/hire event planner</i>	January 1, 2023	March 1, 2023	Applicants have month of January; staff has March to vet
<i>Coordinate local thrift stores & interested campus organizations</i>	March 1, 2023	Flexible	Flexible
<i>Develop educational materials</i>	February 1, 2023	March 20, 2023	7 weeks/20 hours
<i>Develop marketing materials</i>	March 20, 2023	May 22, 2023	9 weeks/25 hours
<i>Purchase event materials/hire photographer</i>	May 22, 2023	July 15, 2023	8 weeks/10 hours
<i>Disperse marketing materials</i>	July 15, 2023	September 15, 2023	9 weeks/25 hours
<i>Host & document event</i>	September 16, 2023	September 16, 2023	1 day/3-hour event
			TOTAL: ~85 hours

Our plan going forward from the first event is streamlined so that the monthly turnaround was very doable. We will have already established connections within the community and local thrift stores, established our educational and marketing materials, and purchased our event materials. Each of these things can be tweaked as necessary, but the groundwork will have been laid.

Here is our proposed monthly plan going forward:

MONTHLY TIMELINE FOR EACH SUBSEQUENT EVENT			
Phase of Project	Start Date	End Date	Time of Proposed Phase
<i>Re-coordinate with local thrift store community & interested campus organizations</i>	Week 1	Week 2	Flexible
<i>Tweak marketing materials (if needed)</i>	Week 2	Week 2	Flexible
<i>Disperse marketing materials in campus and community</i>	Week 2	Week 4	10 hours
<i>Purchase other necessary event materials (if needed)</i>	Week 3	Week 3	Flexible
<i>Tweak education materials (if needed)</i>	Week 3	Week 4	Flexible
<i>Host & document event</i>	Event date (~16 th of month)	Event date (~16 th of month)	1 day/3-hour event
			TOTAL: ~20 hours

IV. Description of Available Facilities

Because we are trying to focus our energy on the UMass Amherst campus and the surrounding community, holding it on the UMass campus is the most logical move. This will go towards efforts of re-invigorating the student body in a post-pandemic world and is most logistically convenient for coordination given our target audience. There is not much needed from the UMass facilities beyond the hosting of the event once a month. The plan is that event planner to work remotely and not need any kind of office, and any storage of materials could easily be done in unused rooms around the UMass campus.

Ideally, we will hold the events outside, weather permitting. This is doable on the Goodell lawn, but other options could include the quad or between the Campus Center and the Student Union. Once the colder weather begins, we will request using space in the Campus Center. The Campus Center basement auditorium goes mostly unused except for large events of this kind, and alternatively we could look at the larger Student Union rooms on the second floor if there were no scheduling conflicts.

V. Qualifications of Personnel

A. *Paid Staff*

There will only be two members of paid staff that will work on this project exclusively, whose stipend salaries are a part of this request for funding as will be covered in the budget section. Both will be chosen by Fashion Revolution USA and the University, but Fashion Revolution USA staff is willing to be the lead on the hiring/vetting process.

Firstly, this will include a hired event planner. This will not be a full-time paid position, but rather a stipend based on part-time planning for the eight events. Once the coordinator was hired, it will be their job to plan the event in tandem with Fashion Revolution USA and the University. Fashion Revolution USA staff is prepared to choose and vet this person between January 1st, 2023, and March 1st, 2023, per our proposed timeline, and we are absolutely open to input from University administration on potential candidates once we move forward.

The second member of paid staff will be a photographer/videographer for the events themselves. As the events will only happen eight times throughout the school year for a few hours a piece, this will also be a stipend salary. We prefer to contract one person for the year, but there could also be new photographers hired for each event on a one-time basis. We think a professional photographer is necessary to place emphasis on tracking the success/progress of the

events so that they can be improved and maintained in coming years and beyond. Again, Fashion Revolution USA can vet this person with the University's input.

B. Volunteers

We would also like include as many enterprising members of the community and student body as are interested. As we've discussed, there have been small-scale efforts towards sustainable repurposing on campus thus far: the Civic Engagement and Service Learning's weekly item swap, the Sustainable Business and Fashion club's work, and the farmers market's occasional thrift tables. Fashion Revolution, with the permission of the University, would like to tap these student body organizations for volunteers and ideas. If uninterested, the coordination will simply continue to be done by the event coordinator and Fashion Revolution staff.



Figure 5: These are just some of the sustainable student organizations UMass promotes, which we can tap for volunteers to be involved in the event series.

VI. Criteria for Judging Success

Tracking the progress of this event series is a crucial part of its development. As it will be an open event to the public, it may be slightly difficult to get a totally accurate read on its success. We will mostly evaluate it through the attendance and feedback of the event. Given that we are prioritizing the employment of a photographer, we will have physical proof of attendance to some degree throughout the events. If the budget allows, expanding the photographer to a videographer would be ideal to piece together the flow of event attendance and create marketing materials for social media. We will also keep track of how many local thrift stores would like to be involved throughout the year; hopefully, we can start with at least two local thrifts and branch out as awareness as the event grows. Ideally, we will have four or five regularly attending stores by the end of the school year. The same goes for other organizations; if there are regularly attending campus club tables, that will likely mean that participation is high. We will be asking any members of the public and campus that are bringing enough items for their own table to register in advance. That registry will be indicative of attendance, as well.

We will also be making feedback a key part of our success criteria. We will be asking the registered members, organizations, and stores for feedback after each event through an email list and phone calls. Incorporating that feedback into subsequent events should boost both quality and attendance of the events. We think it would also be beneficial to ask for feedback at the tables run by Fashion Revolution USA, in the form of a suggestion/comments box. If we can create longstanding engagement with the campus and surrounding community for the event-series, that will be considered successful.

VII. Budget

A. *Salary Expense Breakdown*

Given the amount of work needed to be done by the event planner in the lead up to the first event, we've calculated approximately 85 hours of work in the nine months leading up to the first event on September 16th. Our projected time estimate is roughly 20 hours a month per event, which adds another 140 hours of work over the remainder of the seven events for the rest of the school year. This is all based on our predicted timeline and lengths of tasks in the Timeline section. The agreed industry standard for event planners is \$20/hour, which will culminate in a total stipend salary of \$4500 for the school year.

The other salary expense will be the photographer for the events. There are 8 events throughout the year which we plan to go on for about 3 hours a piece. This will culminate in 24 hours of photography work to be done. The agreed industry standard for photographers is also roughly \$20/hour, which will culminate in a total expense of \$480.

SALARY EXPENSE BREAKDOWN			
Personnel	Total Work Hours (see Timeline)	Salary/hour	Expense
<i>Event Planner</i>	225 hours (85 hours of lead work +140 hours during schoolyear planning)	\$20	\$4,500
<i>Photographer</i>	24 hours (8 events x 3 hours)	\$20	\$480
TOTAL:			\$4,980

B. *Materials Expense Breakdown*

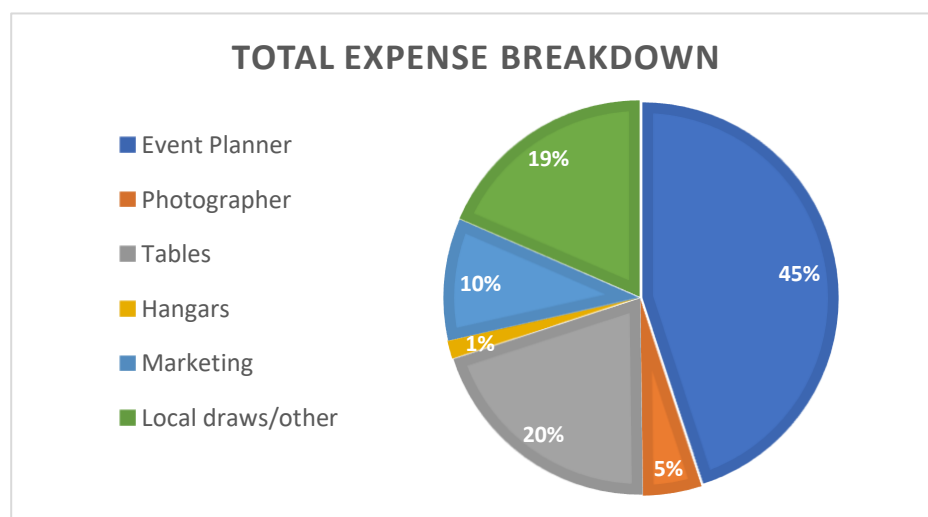
The projected materials we need for this project are tables, hangars, marketing materials & printing capabilities, and some other kind of draw like music and/or refreshments. Given our initial research, which will be finalized by the event planner upon official employment, 20

folding tables could be acquired for roughly \$2,000. Hangars could likely be donated or bought in bulk for roughly \$150. All of these can be reused for subsequent events, but for marketing we'd like to allocate up to \$1,000 for materials over the course of the schoolyear. That leaves \$1,850 for other expenses that arise as well as local draws like live music and/or refreshments. We think it will be impactful to hire local catering for the event and/or a local band to drum up attendance and reinforce the idea of buying local and choosing sustainable practices.

APPROXIMATE MATERIALS EXPENSE BREAKDOWN				
Item	<i>Tables</i>	<i>Hangars</i>	<i>Marketing</i>	<i>Local draws/other</i>
Cost	\$2,020	\$150	\$1000	\$1,850
TOTAL:	\$5,020			

C. *Total Expense Breakdown*

The final summary breakdown involves half the funding going towards the salary expenses to the photographer and event planner. Other necessary materials like event materials, tables, and marketing taking up a significant portion. Given our research into the UMass Amherst Campus budget, there is room to allot this requested \$10,000, especially given the good cause it represents. The total breakdown of the funding is graphically displayed below:



VIII. Summary

If Fashion Revolution USA can acquire the requested funding from the University of Massachusetts Amherst, it would result in an extremely meaningful event series that could truly initiate the conversation about sustainable fashion on-campus and further both organizations' goals towards a more sustainable future. Non-sustainable fashion practices account for a shockingly significant portion of the climate crisis, particularly in college-age demographics given the rise of fast fashion. The proposed event series involves a monthly large-scale swap/tag sale open to students and the public, and we will be involving the local community through partnering with interested local thrifts and catering locally in some capacity.

There is no such organized effort against unsustainable fashion on-campus right now, aside from disorganized small-scale efforts among the student body that only speak to how much of a need there is for this now. The working plan for the events involves opportunities for students to sell and barter used clothing or things, local non-profit thrift stores to promote themselves to the student body and surrounding community, and Fashion Revolution USA to educate a larger audience about their mission of sustainable fashion practices. It will also allow the University of Massachusetts Amherst the opportunity to further its commitment to sustainability on campus and promote campus engagement among the student body post-pandemic.

The potential success of this event series is very well-forecasted. Thrifting and buying second-hand is popular right now, and college-aged students tend to cycle through many items and clothing pieces in their four years. With the right time devoted to marketing, we think attendance will be very high and we could make genuine strides against unsustainable fashion. We can't do it without the University's support, so it is our hope that the value of our work is recognized, and you can join us on our journey of tackling the climate crisis.

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A. Image Credits

Front page: <https://www.ft.com/content/39847318-ab6c-45f2-80b1-e1ea384f3596>

Figure 3 (*Fashion Revolution USA work*): <https://www.elle.fr/Mode/Les-news-mode/Comment-la-Fashion-Revolution-Week-tente-de-changer-le-monde-de-la-mode-3863775>

Figure 4 (*Farmer's market*): <https://www.amherstarea.com/visit/>

Figure 5 (*Sustainable student organizations*): <https://www.umass.edu/sustainability/campus-living-student-activities/sustainable-student-organizations>